Mice and monkeys, elephants, snakes, cows, lions and many other creatures are featured prominently alongside humans in the vast pantheon of Indian culture, in paintings, sculptures and bas-reliefs. Most of these have extremely well-established characters, so much so that their personalities are routinely transposed to human beings. By contrast, says the author, the cat "emerges as...an embodiment of perfidy...clever, scheming, manipulative, even thieving". He goes on to observe that the reader is often invited "to take something from each story involving a cat: a moral, an advice, another look at the world around ourselves".

Cats appear in the *Panchatantra* and in the Buddhist *Jatakas*. They are often shown to be little schemers and troublemakers, but very much part of the larger context of the tale, in which lessons of right and wrong behaviour are being taught. The Islamic world took an altogether fonder view. A story is told of the Prophet's own pet cat: "Muezza by name—who was, once, sleeping on a sleeve of his great robe when the call for prayer came; [the Prophet] cut off that sleeve before picking up the robe, leaving her sleeping rather than disturb her".

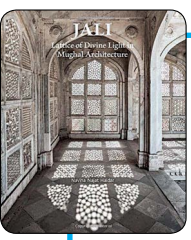
GOSWAMY OBSERVES THAT THE READER IS OFTEN INVITED TO "TAKE SOMETHING FROM EACH STORY...A MORAL, AN ADVICE, ANOTHER LOOK AT THE WORLD AROUND OURSELVES"



The section on paintings is especially interesting. Each painting or sketch on the right-hand page is accompanied on the left by an excellent descriptive text as well as a fragment showing an enlarged view of the cat or cats featured in the painting. The author tells us that artists of the Mughal and later periods, while copying a scene from western paintings, frequently inserted a cat into their interpretations. This is, in my view, a fascinating detail. It is impossible to know now, at this distance in time, whether these inclusions were a form of sly commentary from the local artists! Equally interesting is the fact that most of the depictions are stylised rather than naturalistic, so that the cats look like very tiny lions rather than domestic animals.

While greatly admiring this slender volume, I have one quibble: the printed reproductions on these pages make it very difficult to appreciate the intricacy and precision of the original paintings. ■

Manjula Padmanabhan



Jali: Lattice of Divine Light in Mughal Architecture (Mapin) by the curator-in-charge of Islamic Art at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, Navina Najat Haidar, is a groundbreaking book. Haidar takes us back more than 2,000 years to the roots of Indian architecture tracing the appearance of jali screens in early Buddhist monuments and Hindu temples. She also discusses jali screens through the Sultanate period, much less known than the Mughal period. With contributions by Mitchel Abdul Karim Crites, who for 50 years now has been reviving traditional Indian and Islamic arts and crafts, George Michell, an authority on South Asian architecture, and Ebba Koch, an art and architectural historian, the book is a sumptuous read and production with photography by Abhinav Goswami, who understands light better than almost any other photographer working today. A special treat is the visual discussions of how the tradition of fine jali carving is still alive and how the geometry and abstraction of jali screens still inspire contemporary architects, designers and artists from around the world.



Another of my favourite reads this year was ***Tree & Serpent: Early Buddhist Art in India*** (Mapin). Edited by John Guy, the curator of the show at the Metropolitan Museum in New York, this 368-page catalogue is a delight for the senses. It is not your typical flip-through with rushed glances at the images; it is almost encyclopaedic in its range. Each page is a treasure trove of information, and every image is worth a thousand words. What captivated me is the vast range of interpretations, from the anthropomorphic to the more pictorial portrayals of the Buddha. One intriguing revelation was that of a *shalabhanjika* found in Pompeii. Apart from that, the essays by several scholars provide diverse perspectives. The cover image itself—of a stupa panel with Nagaraja Mucalinda protecting the Buddha—is compelling, layered with an abundance of metaphors.